others winning critical acclaim. For instance, Pan Nalin-directed *Chhello Show*, a coming-of-age drama about a film-obsessed kid that made its way to the Oscar shortlist in the Best International Feature Film category in 2023.

The gamechanger came in 2012 with *Kevi Rite Jaish* (How Will I Leave). A drama, starring Divyang Thakkar and Veronica Gautam, it resonated with the quintessential Gujarati aspiration of chasing success in America. Until then, Gujarati films primarily catered to rural audiences even as the state had witnessed rapid urbanisation. "*Kevi Rite Jaish* alerted Gujarati creators about the potential of [tapping into] urban audiences, who till then were assumed to be Bollywood loyalists," notes Mori. With that came the birth of the 'urban Gujarati film industry'.

Change of Scene

Gujarati cinema has undergone a remarkable transformation ever since. Traditional rural narratives and chaste Gujarati dialogues have given way to urban plots, sleek production values, and a colloquial mix of Gujarati and English, or 'Gujlish'. The settings have moved from bucolic fields to bustling cityscapes and international locales. *Chabutro* (2022), a romance comedy, was shot in the US while at least two films currently in post-production have been filmed in Australia. Songs, too, have evolved, transitioning from bhajans and *raas-garba* to hummable love ballads that capture the essence of modern relationships. Though comedy and romance continue to dominate, the past few years have seen filmmakers venture into diverse genres. From sci-fi films like *Gajab Thai Gayo!* (2022) and *Short Circuit* (2019) to period dramas like *Hellaro*, which won the national award for Best Feature Film in 2019, the scripts reflect an appetite for experimentation.

Mori, also a 2017 Sahitya Akademi Yuva Puraskar recipient, sees hope in the growing diversity of scripts. "The industry is still finding its voice, but the range of stories being told now is encouraging," he says. Despite the highs,



THE BIG EARNERS

The Gujarati film industry has given six 'hits' since 2023



HAHACAR *(2024)*
A situational suspense comedy about three friends who embark on a robbery
Box-office earnings
₹6-7 cr.

JHAMKUDI *(2024)*
A horror comedy based in a village cursed by a witch during Navratri celebrations
B-O earnings
₹20 cr.





3 EKKA *(2023)*
A comedy drama about three friends stuck in financial crises. So what do they do? They open a secret gambling den
B-O earnings
₹30 cr.

ITTAA KITTAA *(2024)*
A family drama about a couple who adopt two girls after being unable to conceive; streaming on Amazon Prime Video
B-O earnings
₹3.5-4 cr.

VASH *(2023)*
A supernatural horror, remade as Ajay Devgn-starring *Shaitaan* in 2024
B-O earnings
₹3 cr.



FAKT PURUSHO MAATE *(2024)*
Amitabh Bachchan has a cameo in this comedy drama about a patriarch who returns from the afterlife to disrupt his grandson's nuptials
B-O earnings: **₹8 cr.**